DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

# Why Are We Here? The Foundation of Everything

Daat Tevunot §8-15

**Sefer:** Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §8-15 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 8 September 2022

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

## Where we left off (§8-9)

The book is a conversation between the Neshamah and the Sekhel. The Neshamah believes in the principles of faith but struggles to reconcile them with the world it sees, especially God's involvement in the world, reward and punishment and the end of days. The Sekhel warned in §8 that these are deep matters, such as "saddik vera lo, rasha vetov lo," questions Moshe Rabbenu himself asked, and we do not know that he received a full answer.

In §9 the Neshamah accepts this: it does not need every detail, only the kelalim, the principles. The Rabbi gives an example. For why the righteous suffer, we can give general principles that we have discussed in the past: gilgul, punishment in this world, testing. Those are kelalim. But the pratim, why this person went through X and that person through Y, cannot always be understood, and the Neshamah is not asking for them.

A participant asked whether the soul struggles because it is trapped in the body. The Rabbi clarified that "Neshamah" in this book means the emotions, the heart. The Sekhel says: you know the 13 principles. The Neshamah says: I understand them, but I do not feel them.

## Justice is certain (§10-11)

The Sekhel states what is beyond doubt: the Holy One, blessed be He, established His world on justice and runs it with straight and faithful judgment. As Moshe testified at the end of the Torah, "HaSur tamim paolo, ki khol derakhav mishpat," the Rock, His work is perfect, all His ways are just.

The Rabbi asked when we say this verse. At the end of a funeral, in the prayer called Sidduk HaDin, the vindication of the judgment. That is the best time to say it, because it is the moment when emotion does not match intellect. We know and believe that God runs everything, but someone has been lost and it feels as though Hashem has left. So we reaffirm what we know.

The Neshamah answers in §11: this straightness and depth of God's justice is exactly what I want to understand properly and in a structured way. That, the Rabbi says, is the end of the introduction. The paragraphs will now get much longer.

## Before the questions: what are we doing here? (§12-13)

The English edition starts a new chapter here ("Fundamental Concepts"), though the Ramhal's book has no chapters. The Sekhel says that before discussing God's rule of the world, we must first understand ourselves: what is our existence and our service for? Every thinking person has asked what we are doing on this earth.

The Neshamah agrees that this is the very thing it is seeking. The Rabbi compares the Sekhel to a good psychologist. Someone comes with a presenting problem, and underneath it is a more basic issue. Before you ask why the world looks the way it does or what will happen at the end, ask: what is your purpose?

## The foundation: to complete yourself (§14)

"Underline this ten times," said the Rabbi. "This is the whole Ramhal philosophy in a nutshell." The Sekhel says that a person is to complete himself, and also the world around him, and that this is his zekhut and his reward.

- Very few people reach full completion. If you cannot reach 100%, aim for 99, or 90, 80, 70. Reach some part of completion.
- People differ in potential. This explains an apparent contradiction about Moshe: there will never be a prophet like him, yet we are told a person can become greater than Moshe. In personal development, relative to your own potential, you can go further; the level Moshe reached, you will never reach.
- Zekhut means it is yours. You earned it through your own work and toil toward completion.

## There is no "reward" the way children think of it

The Rabbi has often said that there is no concept of reward in the Torah in the sense of "I do X and God gives me Y." That is the immature version we were taught as children. "Sekhar misvah misvah": the reward of a misvah is the misvah itself, that I have become a better person. The better a person is, the more he can connect with Hashem, and that connection is olam haba.

He illustrated it with the Queen, whose passing was being marked that day. She was the epitome of dignity. To spend time with her you had to prepare and become dignified yourself. If someone spent years learning to act royally and so the Queen chose to spend more time with him, it would be wrong to call that his reward. It is simply the reality: he has become royal, he has more affinity with her, so they can be together.

Likewise with the gym. Working out and losing weight is not a reward; it is cause and effect. A reward would be if someone handed you a pill to lose weight because you went to the gym. Same result, but not intrinsically linked. "You do misvot, naturally your sekhar is that you become a better person. Full stop."

## Questions from the group

- **What about physical blessings promised for misvot?** The Rambam asks exactly this and answers that all such rewards are there to help us serve better. It is harder to complete

yourself while struggling with poverty. When a person's mind is full of worries he cannot work on himself or connect. The blessings give us an olam hazeh free to serve Hashem.

- **Is the good feeling after helping someone the reward?** The Rabbi said the feeling is short-lived and is not the barometer. In his view it comes from the beliefs we were brought up with: all feelings and emotions stem from beliefs. Someone raised to value power might feel good pushing another down. The real reward is the identity you are creating for yourself. Of course being kind is a misvah, and of course you should feel good; just do not think the feeling is the reward.

## The next question (§15)

The Neshamah responds: "This is a foundation that includes many cornerstones." The Rabbi notes that this is the Ramhal's poetry telling the reader to pay attention. The soul then pushes deeper: why did Hashem want us to complete ourselves at all? That question is left for the next class.

## Summary

- §8-11 close the introduction: God's justice is certain ("ki khol derakhav mishpat"), and the Neshamah wants to understand it, not only believe it.
- Before addressing the world, the Sekhel asks the prior question: what is the purpose of human existence?
- The foundation of the Ramhal's thought: a person is to complete himself and his world, and that is his zekhut and reward.
- Reward is not a separate prize; like getting fit from exercise, becoming better is the reward and brings closeness to Hashem.
- The Neshamah now asks why God wanted us to complete ourselves.

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